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GDP growth estimated at 7.7% in 2025-26: data

Earlier this year, the government also updated the base year of the GDP data to 2022-23 and improved its methodology.

The data shows that the manufacturing sector is estimated to have grown at 10.7% in 2025-26 as compared to 9.3% in the first revised estimates for 2024-25. However, in Q4 of 2025-26, the sector grew at 7.3%, as opposed to 11.8% in the same quarter of the previous year. The “trade, repair, hotels, transport, communication & services related to broadcasting and storage” sector similarly saw its growth estimate quicken to 11% in 2025-26 from 6.6% in 2024-25. In Q4, the sector accelerated to 12.4% from 6.3% in Q4 of 2024-25. The agriculture sector, however, is expected to see growth slowing to 3% in 2025-26 from 4.2% in the previous year, with growth in Q4 slowing to 3.6% from 3.8% in the fourth quarter of 2024-25.

The data also shows that the growth of private final consumption expenditure is estimated to have quickened to 7.7% in 2025-26 from 5.8% in the previous year. Asset creation and investment, in the form of gross fixed capital formation, is also estimated to have grown 8.2% in 2025-26 from 6.4% in 2024-25.

GDP growth estimated at 7.7% in 2025-26: govt.

Provisional estimates are slightly higher than the 7.6% growth projected in February; growth in Q4 stands at 7.8%; PM Modi says the figures show the success of reforms and the hard work of Indians

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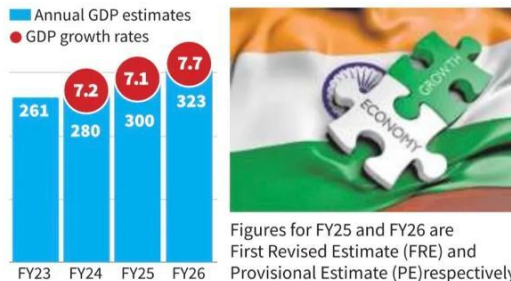
The growth in India's gross domestic product (GDP) has been estimated at 7.7% in 2025-26, according to data released by the government on Friday, compared with 7.1% in the previous financial year of 2024-25. GDP growth in the fourth quarter of 2025-26 stood at 7.8%.

According to the data released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, the provisional estimates of GDP growth in 2025-26 are slightly higher than the 7.6% growth estimated in February 2026.

The data comes at a time when Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra, while an-

Stronger estimate

India's GDP is estimated to grow by 7.7% in 2025-26, slightly faster than the 7.6% estimated in February 2026. In the chart below, the bars show annual GDP estimates (in ₹ lakh crore) and the circles indicate growth rates at constant prices (in %).



nouncing the Monetary Policy Committee's decisions, said that GDP growth for 2026-27 was expected to slow to 6.6%.

In the press conference on the GDP data, Chief Economic Advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran said that

the RBI's assessment on growth and inflation “seems fair estimates” and that he didn't see the need to second-guess them.

“GDP growth rate of 7.7% in FY 2025-26 and 7.8% in Q4 of FY 2025-26 reflect the inherent

strength of our economy, the success of reforms and the hard work of 140 crore Indians,” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on X following the data release. “We shall leave no stone unturned to further ‘Ease of Living,’ ‘Ease of Doing Business’ and increase opportunities for our youth.”

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, on X, emphasised that manufacturing, trade, repair, hotels, transport, communication & services related to broadcasting, storage and financial, real estate and professional services sectors hit double-digit growth at both constant and current prices in 2025-26.

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Maulana Barkatullah



Maulana Barkatullah: 'First PM of India' whose name varsity wants to drop

Yashee

New Delhi, May 5

THE EXECUTIVE council of Bhopal's Barkatullah University has passed a proposal to change its name to Vagdevi Bhojpal University. The university got its current name in 1988, before which it was called Bhopal University. Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali was a freedom fighter and the 'first prime minister of independent India', as he along with some associates, most notably Raja Mahendra Pratap, set up India's first 'government in exile' in Kabul in 1915.

"Maulana Barkatullah devoted his life to working for India's freedom abroad. From Japan to England to US to Germany to Russia to Afghanistan, he travelled to several countries, creating awareness for and building alliances to usher in India's independence. He died in 1927 in the US, which is probably why his activities weren't widely known back home. The recognition given to him in 1988, by naming a university after him in his hometown, had been a long-due

honour," said Chaman Lal, Honorary Advisor, Bhagat Singh Archives and Resource Centre, New Delhi. Lal, a retired JNU professor, said that instead of changing the university's name, more should be done to popularise the legacy of Barkatullah.

His beliefs, ideals

Maulana Barkatullah is believed to have been born on July 7, 1854, in Bhopal. A meritorious student, he went to Bombay and then London for studies. He started teaching in Liverpool, where he came into contact with Indian revolutionaries. His articles and speeches attracted negative attention from the government, after which he left for the US in 1899. Here, he corresponded with the freedom fighter Maulana Hasrat Mohani (who coined the slogan Inquilab Zindabad). The letters give a clear idea of his views.

An article by Iqbal Husain that appeared in the *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, Vol. 66 (2005-2006), quotes from one of the letters. "Nearly 20 million people have perished due to starvation and hunger.



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These poverty-stricken people were both Hindus and Muslims... an entire country has perished due to hunger," Barkatullah wrote. Barkatullah firmly believed that the British could be driven out of India only if Hindus and Muslims fought shoulder to shoulder and resisted the divide-and-rule ploy.

"What makes Barkatullah special is his strong belief that India could only be free if



PHOTO COURTESY: CHAMAN LAL

Maulana Barkatullah (left): his gravestone at a cemetery in Sacramento, US.

all its communities stood together. He worked closely with Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs, and people from every region," said Ali Na-deem Rezavi, Secretary, Indian History Congress, and Professor of History at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU). "The best example of this is the Provisional Government of India set up in Kabul in 1915. He, along with Raja Mahendra Pratap, a Hindu

prince, and Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi, a great Islamic thinker, formed a government in exile. Raja Mahendra Pratap became president, and Barkatullah became prime minister. This was one of the first times Indians had set up their own independent political body outside British control. This story is important not just because it challenged the British, but because it showed a vision of India where people of different faiths fought for a common goal," Rezavi said.

Govt in Kabul, meeting Lenin

During World War I, Barkatullah and his associates travelled to Germany and tried to convince captured Indian soldiers to form an army against the British. He also worked prominently for the Ghadar Party, founded by Lala Har Dayal in 1913, which aimed to win independence through armed struggle.

Then on December 1, 1915, the 'Provisional Government of India' was formed in Kabul. Four years later, the leaders of this 'government' travelled to Moscow to meet Vladimir Lenin, the leader of Soviet Russia.

After the British victory in World War I, the Indian revolutionaries' plans suffered major reverses. However, Barkatullah kept travelling — to Belgium, Switzerland, France — working for his cause.

"Unlike many freedom fighters who worked from inside the country, Barkatullah spent most of his life in exile. He connected with anti-colonial movements around the world and became one of the most well-known Indian revolutionaries of his time. Inspired by resistance efforts in the Muslim world, he believed that justice was a global cause and that India's freedom was part of that larger fight," Rezavi said.

In 1927, despite failing health, he travelled to California for a Ghadar Party event. This is where, in September 1927, he breathed his last. He was laid to rest in Sacramento, with Raja Mahendra Pratap by his side till the end.

Both Rezavi and Chaman Lal pointed out that the Union government is working to popularise Raja Mahendra Pratap, and Barkatullah, as his close associate, should get the same treatment.

More than a century after the first tuberculosis vaccine was introduced, the world is struggling to control one of its oldest diseases. Tuberculosis (TB) continues to kill more people annually than any other infectious disease, surpassing even the COVID-19 pandemic at its peak. Yet, there is still no effective vaccine for adolescents and adults.

Once exposed to *Mycobacterium tuberculosis*, individuals may get infected and remain asymptomatic for years. Others develop subclinical disease, showing minimal or no symptoms while harbouring infection. A subset progresses to active TB, which may manifest as pulmonary TB (PTB) – the infectious form that drives transmission – or as extrapulmonary TB (EPTB), which affects organs beyond the lungs and is harder to diagnose, more debilitating, and sometimes fatal.

No one-size-fits-all vaccine

With such diversity in disease pathways, expecting a single “one-shot” vaccine to prevent all forms of TB may be unrealistic. This expectation has shaped global disappointment in TB vaccine development especially since most previous trials have focused primarily on preventing pulmonary TB.

Meanwhile, the burden remains immense. In many low- and middle-income countries, TB incidence ranges between 200 and 300 per 100,000 population. Reducing this to 10-20 per 100,000 – the threshold for elimination – will require sustained effort and enormous public health investment. For India, which carries one of the world's highest TB burdens, the challenge is systemic.

India's goal of eliminating TB is ambitious and necessary. But achieving it will require a holistic approach towards all forms of disease and all age groups moving beyond the search for a perfect solution and embracing a layered, pragmatic approach. As tools are discovered and tested, decisions will need to be made on their deployment.

The first layer is better detection. Advances in diagnostics, including tools for identifying subclinical TB, can help identify individuals at risk earlier. The second is preventive therapy, ensuring that those with latent infection receive treatment before progressing to active disease. The third – arguably the most complex – is vaccination. However, access to diagnostics and preventive therapy remains uneven, making vaccination an especially critical pillar.

Recent findings from the BMJ-published PreVenTB trial conducted by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) provide such an opportunity. Conducted across 18 sites in India and involving more than 12,700 household contacts of TB patients, the trial evaluated VPM1002 developed by SIPL and Immuvac developed by Cadila, in a real-world, high-risk population aged six years and above, including



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individuals with comorbidities and varying infection status closely reflecting real life conditions.

The trial reported efficacy of VPM1002 and Immuvac as: 50.4% efficacy of VPM1002 against extrapulmonary TB (statistically significant); 64.6% efficacy of VPM1002 in children aged 6-14 years against all TB (PTB and EPTB); More than 60% efficacy of Immuvac against EPTB in children aged 6-10 years; more than 60% efficacy against progression to disease among those developing latent infection during follow-up and overall 21.4% efficacy of VPM1002 against all TB (Reference: Subho Sarkar, Consultant Intervention Pulmonologist; from LinkedIn). These are not trivial findings.

Extrapulmonary TB is the hidden burden of the epidemic, harder to diagnose, frequently missed, and associated with significant morbidity and mortality. A reduction of over 50% in such cases represents a meaningful clinical and public health impact, including reduced health-care costs and patient suffering.

The data also highlight a strong signal in school-age children and adolescents, where efficacy exceeded 60% which is an add-on benefit of vaccination in this age group. This is particularly relevant because India currently has no structured TB vaccination strategy beyond infancy. If confirmed, this could open the door to a booster-dose TB prevention strategy.

Need for nutritional support

Another important piece of evidence generated from study is the role of nutrition. Reduced efficacy was observed in individuals with low body mass index (BMI), underscoring the need for nutritional support for vaccines to work optimally in undernourished in context of broader health determinants.

From a programmatic standpoint, VPM1002 offers additional advantages. It is a single-dose vaccine based on a modified BCG platform, making it operationally simpler than multi-dose, adjuvanted vaccines in development. In a country of India's scale, logistical simplicity is a decisive advantage. The vaccine can be manufactured at large scale and cost effectively.

TB is largely a disease of low and middle income countries (LMIC) and their governments must act proactively. Waiting for expansive solutions developed elsewhere is neither practical nor sustainable. LMICs cannot afford to wait for a silver bullet, because there is no one-stop solution for TB, especially when there are results from a Phase III trial conducted in an Indian population across all age groups (six years and above) and against all forms of TB, including PTB and EPTB. It is to be noted that no other TB vaccine trial till date has studied efficacy against EPTB and none of the currently ongoing trials worldwide has included EPTB as the efficacy end-point.

India has navigated similar public health

decisions before. TrueNat was the first ‘make in India’ Molecular test approved and adopted by the National TB Elimination Programme before its World Health Organization pre-qualification study.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Bharat Biotech's Covaxin was initially approved in “clinical trial mode” to enable early access while additional data continued to accumulate. That decision was driven not by perfection, but by urgency and it helped accelerate protection at a critical time.

India has also demonstrated this approach with indigenous rotavirus vaccines, which were introduced despite modest efficacy and wide confidence intervals. Since then, they have helped reduce severe disease and child mortality and have been incorporated into the national immunisation programme (Bhandari et al., *The Lancet*, 2014).

A smarter TB strategy

TB is, in many ways, a slow-moving pandemic. Yet, it has not always been met with the same urgency in policy action. The policy question, therefore, is how innovations, including moderately effective vaccines such as VPM1002 and Immuvac, can be intelligently integrated into the TB elimination programme. Targeted use among household contacts, deployment in school-age children, and alignment with nutrition and preventive therapy programmes could together lead to a more effective TB control framework. A combination of vaccines effective across different indications and age groups may be needed to have an impact.

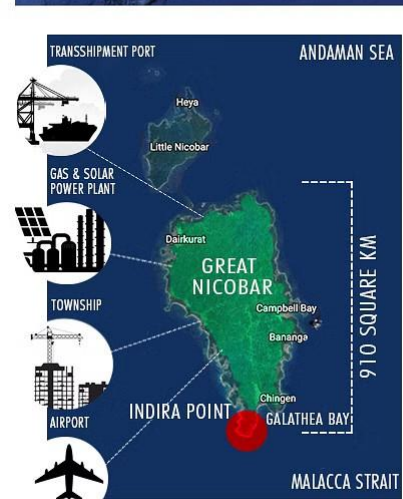
India's TB challenge is unlikely to be solved by a single breakthrough. It will require a combination of early detection, preventive treatment, targeted vaccination against both pulmonary and extrapulmonary TB, case-based clinical management, nutritional supplementation, and sustained public health investment.

Waiting for a perfect vaccine may delay progress indefinitely, especially when no trial other than the PreVenTB trial has evaluated vaccine efficacy against both pulmonary and extrapulmonary TB in individuals aged six years and above. In contrast, deploying tools that reduce severe disease, particularly EPTB, can deliver immediate and tangible benefits.

The PreVenTB trial trial is comprehensive, well-designed and well conducted, offering a meaningful signal – perhaps a light at the end of the tunnel in TB vaccine development. Given the urgency of the challenge and the limited time to act, we must focus on solutions that are available today and supported by robust evidence of efficacy against both PTB and EPTB in individuals aged six years and above under real-world conditions, rather than wait indefinitely in the hope that better options may emerge in the future – an outcome that is far from certain.

New Indian vaccine trial data show meaningful protection against extrapulmonary TB, underscoring the need for targeted vaccination alongside stronger public health strategies

THE GREAT NICOBAR PROJECT



The Great Nicobar Island is strategically located astride the sea lanes approaching the Strait of Malacca — the most critical choke point in the Indo-Pacific. The distance from the island's tip, the Indira Point, to Indonesia's Aceh region is a mere 80 nautical miles (148 km). The central government says the project, considering its "strategic and economic importance", will put India on the world map of transcontinental cargo trade.

The Great Nicobar Project: A Holistic Folly

Its claims of strategic significance are questionable, while environmental harm is certain.

The Project for Holistic Development of Great Nicobar Island, a ₹81,000 crore mega infrastructure project, is more folly than national gain. With growing opposition to the project, including legal challenges, the government has cloaked the project in the language of national security. This is despite the fact that the original project documents, including the 2021 request for proposal issued by the NRI Aayog, hardly refer to defence or security, making it clear that, in its actual intent, the project is a purely commercial endeavour built on large-scale destruction of the ecologically pristine islands and the alienation of their indigenous people.

The project envisions an international container trans-shipment terminal at Galathea Bay, a greenfield international airport, a township and tourism project, and a power plant. The primary trunk infrastructure of the programme alone is slated to destroy 130 square kilometres of primarily tropical rainforests, which, by the government's underestimation, will involve felling 8.65 lakh trees, a fraction of the likely millions. This will, in a hare-brained plan, be compensated by planting a few lakh trees in distant Haryana and Madhya Pradesh. The Nicobars are the only region in India to fall in the Sundaland global biodiversity hotspot, home to rare and endemic species and globally unique flora and fauna. The notion that the destruction of this ecological hotspot can be compensated for by tree plantations in semi-arid central and northern India is foolish fiction. The Galathea Bay—where the trans-shipment terminal is proposed—is among the most important nesting sites of the endangered leatherback turtle. In January 2021, contradicting the government's own National Marine Turtle Action Plan, the Galathea Bay was denotified as a protected sanctuary to make way for the infrastructure project.

Almost every step of the project's progress is characterised by opacity and violation of existing rules and regulations. Experts highlight that the environmental impact assessment conducted in 2022, which gave clearance to the project, submitted incorrect or incomplete information and failed to follow the appropriate procedure. The process of obtaining individual and community rights under the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 was completed in less than 20 days, and the gram sabhas constituted for hearing the project, and which eventually cleared the proposal, largely comprised settlers, not indigenous tribes. Nor was the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes consulted on the matter. The consent of the tribal people was forced and coerced, according to the Nicobarese.

The fig leaf of national security and strategic relevance has been debunked by several experts within the defence fraternity. For one, the security needs of the island need not be linked to a destructive and commercial mega-infrastructure project. They can be addressed in a much more targeted manner with efficiency, for instance, by revamping the existing military infrastructure at INS Baaz. In fact, the navy's plans to extend its airfield and construct a naval jetty at Campbell Bay have been awaiting government approval for the last five years. Second, the project, by bringing in an estimated three lakh new settlers into the island and promoting large-scale tourism, puts new pressures on the military in a location of strategic vulnerability. This is, in fact, a burden on India's defence infrastructure. Third, while the project is floated as India's response to growing Chinese influence by offering it an opportunity to choke the Strait of Malacca and economically constrain China, experts point out that the Strait of Malacca is hardly a chokepoint for China, which has alternate routes through the Straits of Lombok and Makassar. Military capabilities may help deal with China's influence, but certainly not a trans-shipment terminal and township project.

The economic logic behind the project is also questionable. With no real hinterland, no industrial zone or logistics base, every cargo must be double-handled, significantly driving up costs and operational challenges. Galathea Bay is also too geographically isolated to support cost-effective feeder operations. There is also no guarantee that the existence of a trans-shipment terminal will help India wrest traffic from competing ports like Colombo and Singapore, given that shipping traffic is heavily dependent on connectivity and feeder links. The project is also seeing considerable cost escalation and might end up with the government subsidising expenses to the benefit of a few private conglomerates. Far from being a viable project for development, it risks becoming an expensive public investment whose gains are privatised while its costs are socialised.

From the point of view of the local tribes, it is fair to see the project as continuing the logic of settler colonialism. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands have been a historical example of the process at play, beginning with the British penal colonies, continuing post-independence to the settlement of ex-servicemen families in Great Nicobar and the alienation of indigenous communities from their land and their confinement into permanent shelters, as with the Nicobarese in the aftermath of the 2004 tsunami. The Great Nicobar project is a high-decibel manifestation of this logic. In its current commercial scale, devoid of economic, ecological, or strategic benefits, the project must be reassessed and reconsidered by the state, lest India reap the bitter fruits of its own folly.

THE GREAT NICOBAR PROJECT

India's Strategic Infrastructure Push

The International Container Transshipment Port at Great Nicobar, located near the Strait of Malacca that carries nearly 30% of global container traffic, will position India as a pivotal hub in global shipping by drawing cargo flows from major ports across the region while reducing logistics costs, boosting maritime security, and strengthening India's role in global trade.



Source: Media Reports



Thank you

“The price of success is daily effort”



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